



Beyond Panama Relocation

2026 EDITION



THE COMPLETE EXPAT GUIDE

Living in Panama

Everything you need to relocate, invest and build your future in the world's best country for expats.

Presented by Beyond Panama Relocation · Your relocation partner

Inside this guide

Eighteen chapters covering every decision in your move to Panama — from climate and cost of living to residency visas, banking and concrete next steps.

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HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Each chapter stands on its own — jump straight to the one that matters most to you. Figures are drawn from data verified to 2025 and from the field experience of Beyond Panama Relocation. All amounts are in US dollars (USD).

01 THE DESTINATION Introduction — Why Panama?

Panama has positioned itself as one of the world's most attractive destinations for expats, retirees, investors and remote workers. Its blend of political stability, first-world infrastructure, affordable cost of living and accessible residency programs makes it an option without equal in Latin America.

#1

Country to live in as an expat — InterNations, published by Forbes (2024)

130+

International banks · the financial hub of Latin America

0%

Tax on income earned outside Panama

\$1,620

Comfortable monthly budget for a couple in Boquete

KEY International recognition

An InterNations study (2024) published by Forbes ranked Panama the **#1 country to live in as an expat** worldwide. The Gallup Global Wellbeing Index placed it first for two consecutive years, and *International Living* consistently rates it among the best countries to retire.

■ The eight factors that change everything

KEY FACTOR	WHY IT MATTERS
Cost of living	Single: from \$1,000–\$1,200/mo . Couple: \$1,500–\$2,000/mo in non-premium areas
Quality of life	Modern hospitals, excellent highways, advanced telecoms, nightlife and culture
Climate	No snow, temperatures of 24–32 °C. No hurricanes. Dry season (Dec–Apr) and rainy season (May–Nov)
Stability	Stable democracy, dollarized economy, no central bank, 130+ international banks
Language	Spanish is official; strong English presence in Panama City, Boquete and Coronado
Taxes	Territorial system: foreign income and pensions are not taxed in Panama
Accessibility	Tocumen is Central America's largest airport, with direct flights worldwide
Expat community	Thousands of active expats in Panama City, Boquete, Coronado and beyond

02 THE LAND Geography, landscape & climate

Panama is the southernmost country in Central America: an isthmus —a narrow strip of land with ocean on both sides— linking Central and South America. It borders Costa Rica to the west and Colombia to the east; the Pacific forms its southern edge and the Caribbean its northern one. Panama City is the capital and largest city.

The 10 provinces

The country is divided into 10 provinces, each with its own character, subdivided into districts and corregimientos. Crossing provincial borders by road may involve checkpoints where passport and driver's license are requested.

PROVINCE	CAPITAL / REF.	DESCRIPTION
Panama	Panama City	National capital. 1.5M+ people, major airport, the Canal, banking, Casco Viejo and Panama Viejo
Panama Oeste	La Chorrera	Strip between the Canal and Coclé. Fast-growing suburb. Chame, Coronado, Gorgona and Altos del María beaches
Coclé	Penonomé	Dry zone with an airport at Río Hato. The «Panama» hat, El Valle de Antón (dormant volcano), windmills
Herrera	Chitré	The smallest. Azuero Peninsula. Clay crafts, colonial history, agriculture (sugar cane, corn)
Los Santos	Las Tablas	Cultural hotspot. World-famous Carnival and Pollera. Pedasí, Playa Venao, surf and Isla Iguana
Veraguas	Santiago	One of the largest. Coiba Marine Park. Rapid growth, mega-mall. Santa Fe in the mountains
Chiriquí	David	Panama's «breadbasket»: produces most of its food. Boquete (world coffee), Volcán, Cerro Punta
Bocas del Toro	Bocas Town	Caribbean archipelago. Nine islands. Surf, snorkel, backpacker vibe. Most people speak English
Colón	Colón City	World's second-largest free-trade zone. Caribbean side of the Canal. Cruise port. Portobelo
Darién	La Palma	The largest and least populated. Pure jungle, a natural border with Colombia. The Pan-American Highway ends here

Panama sits about 8 degrees above the equator, with a tropical monsoon climate. No snow and no hurricanes. Temperature and humidity depend mainly on elevation and proximity to the ocean.

VARIABLE	COAST / SEA LEVEL	HIGHLANDS (E.G. BOQUETE, 3,500 FT)
Average temperature	29-32 °C (85-90 °F)	~24 °C (76 °F) — permanent spring
Humidity	High, especially on both coasts	Moderate, cooler and less humid
Dry season	December to April	December to April
Rainy season	May to November (afternoon showers)	May to November
Annual rainfall	~269 cm (106 in) average	Varies by area
Altitude rule	—	~2 °C cooler per 300 m of elevation



THE ESSENTIALS

Country fact file

ITEM	INFORMATION
Official name	Republic of Panama
Population	~4,468,000 people. Over 70% live in urban areas (the highest rate in Central America)
Main cities	Panama City, David, Colón
Indigenous peoples	~12% of the population
Life expectancy	77.37 years
Official language	Spanish. English is a second language in business, banking and tourist areas
Time zone	EST (GMT-5) year-round. No daylight saving
Measurement	Metric system (km, liters, kg). Fuel in liters, speed in km/h
Electricity	120V / 60Hz, flat US-style plugs
Currency	Balboa (1:1 with the USD). The US dollar is legal tender
No central bank	Money supply is market-driven: greater financial stability
Banking	130+ international banks. The financial hub of Latin America

Language — a practical guide

Spanish is the official language. English has a strong presence in Panama City, Boquete, Coronado and Bocas del Toro (where it coexists with Caribbean Creole). In the rural interior, Spanish is almost exclusive.

- ✓ Learning basic Spanish is highly recommended before moving
- ✓ Cultural immersion is the fastest learning method
- ✓ Duolingo, private tutors and language schools are available
- ✓ Spanish is not considered a complex language for English speakers

TIME ZONE — DETAIL	DIFFERENCE
Winter (Nov–Mar) vs. US Eastern	Same as EST (no difference)
Winter vs. US Central	Panama is 1 hour ahead (CST)
Summer (Mar–Nov) vs. US Eastern	Panama is 1 hour ahead (EDT)
Summer vs. US Central	Same as CDT

METRIC	QUICK EQUIVALENT
1 meter	~1.09 yards (3.28 ft)
100 km/h	62 mph
10 kg	~22 lbs
4 liters	~1 gallon
30 °C	86 °F



Cost of living in detail

The cost of living in Panama is markedly lower than in most Western countries. You won't live «like royalty on pennies», but a comfortable first-world lifestyle is entirely within reach. Geography is the single biggest factor in your budget.

PROFILE	BUDGET AREA	MID-RANGE AREA	PREMIUM AREA*
Single person	\$1,000-\$1,200	\$1,200-\$1,800	\$2,000-\$3,500+
Couple	\$1,500-\$2,000	\$2,000-\$2,800	\$3,000-\$5,000+

Monthly figures in USD. *Premium areas: Panama City, Boquete and Coronado.

A real budget — a couple in Boquete

CATEGORY	MONTHLY COST (USD)
Rent (2-bed house, furnished)	\$750
Groceries & supermarket	\$300
Electricity	\$25 (up to 4× in hot areas with A/C)
Health insurance (2 people)	\$175
Doctor & dentist (copays)	\$10
Medications	\$10
Streaming	\$10
Internet + Cable TV	\$60
Clothing & footwear	\$30
Entertainment & dining	\$50
Domestic & international travel	\$100
Gardener & house help	\$50
Car insurance & maintenance	\$50
Approximate total	\$1,620

If rent rises, the budget scales accordingly. A/C can push electricity to \$100-\$125/mo on the coast.

SERVICE / ITEM	PANAMA	US REFERENCE
Doctor visit (office)	Under \$20	\$150-\$400 uninsured
Public hospital visit	\$2	No comparable
Full emergency (with surgery)	\$119.80 (real case)	\$5,000-\$15,000+
Monthly health insurance (age 66)	\$117/mo	\$800-\$1,200/mo
Typical local lunch	\$4-\$5	\$12-\$20
Internet + Cable TV	~\$60/mo	\$100-\$180/mo
Mobile phone (unlimited)	~\$30/mo	\$60-\$90/mo
2-bed furnished rental (Boquete)	\$750-\$800	\$1,800-\$3,000+
Medications	~1/3 of US price	Full price
Golf (monthly membership)	\$100 in Chitré	\$300-\$800

Mobile phone

Phones need a local SIM or eSIM; US handsets must be unlocked. The main carriers are Tigo, Claro, Movistar and +Móvil.

ASPECT	DETAIL
SIM cost	~\$5 to activate; staff help you set it up in-store
Typical monthly plan	~\$30/mo: unlimited calls + data + international calls
Coverage	Very good across most of the country
No contract	Prepaid option available, no commitment
Basic handset	You can buy a phone in Panama from \$100

Internet service

PROVIDER / TYPE	DETAIL
Tigo / Más Móvil (fiber)	~\$40/mo · 300–1,000 Mbps · the most common option in urban areas
Starlink (satellite)	Ideal for rural, coastal or mountain areas without cable
Starlink advantage	High speed even in isolated communities; transforms the interior
Cable TV	English and Spanish channels via local operators
Streaming	Firestick + Prime, Netflix, Apple TV; may require a VPN

NOTE WhatsApp is the key platform

It is the primary means of communication in Panama for everything: calls, messages and documents. Individuals, businesses, professionals and expat communities all use it. Downloading it on arrival is **essential**.

Water & electricity

UTILITY	INFORMATION
Electricity	120V / 60Hz, US-style plugs. Reliable service; possible outages in electrical storms
Drinking water (mainland)	Considered safe to drink; many homes have a reserve tank with extra filter
Water on the islands	Bottled water is recommended exclusively
Electricity (mountains)	~\$25/mo in Boquete/Volcán thanks to the cool climate, no A/C
Electricity (coast)	Can be 4-5× higher due to heavy air-conditioning use



WELLBEING

Healthcare & insurance

Panama offers internationally accredited healthcare at a fraction of the cost in home countries. Many doctors in Panama City hospitals trained in the US and speak English.

Reference hospitals

HOSPITAL	RELEVANT DETAIL
Pacífica Salud (Panama City)	The only hospital affiliated with Johns Hopkins International in all of Latin America
Hospital Paitilla (Panama City)	Affiliated with Cleveland Clinic . High medical specialization
Hospital Santa Fe (Panama City)	Health insurance available with no age restriction
Hospital Chiriquí (David)	Reference for the entire west. 24/7 emergency
Hospital Bocas del Toro	New 24/7 hospital on Isla Colón
Volcán public hospital	24/7 for Volcán and Cerro Punta
Chitré public hospital	The most modern and largest on the Azuero Peninsula
Boquete (new)	Public hospital under construction; opening expected 2025

Real cost of care

SERVICE	DOCUMENTED REAL COST
General consultation (private)	Under \$20 without insurance
Public hospital consultation	Just \$2 per visit
Full emergency*	\$119.80 total (ER + surgeon + IV + tests + medication)
Medications	~1/3 of US price. Most available over the counter
Pharmacy + Pensionado	10% extra off already very low prices
Common practice	The doctor gives you their personal cell for follow-up

**Real case, no insurance used: ER + on-call surgeon + tests + IV + medication.*

Health insurance options

TYPE	MONTHLY COST	COVERAGE
Local plan (age 66)	\$117/mo	80% of costs, 100% hospitalization, no deductible
International plan (age 50)	\$85/mo	No deductible in Panama; \$1,000 abroad
Hospital Santa Fe	Variable	Full plans, no age limit
Medicare Advantage (US)	Your current plan	Emergencies with direct billing at select hospitals
Self-insure	\$0 premium	Preferred by many expats given how low costs are
US Veterans (VA)	Per benefits	Care for service-related disabilities

07 WHERE TO LIVE Best places to live

Panama has something for every lifestyle: cosmopolitan metropolis, beach, mountains, farmland and Caribbean paradise. Areas split between «popular expat hubs» —more services, pricier— and «undiscovered towns» —cheaper, deeper cultural immersion.

Popular expat hubs

Panama City

\$1,200+

PANAMA

A metropolis: the Canal, airport, Johns Hopkins & Cleveland Clinic hospitals, banking, malls and nightlife. Minimal culture shock for newcomers.

Coronado & beaches

\$1,000–2,500

PANAMA OESTE

2nd-largest expat community. Beach, golf, international school, 1 hr from the city. Cheaper to the west (Playa Blanca ~\$1,000).

El Valle de Antón

\$1,200+

COCLÉ

Inside the crater of a dormant volcano. Cool climate, nature, hot springs. Upscale, resort feel, 2 hrs from the city.

Pedasí

\$800+

LOS SANTOS

Small, with a growing expat community. Excellent surf and fishing beaches. Very laid-back; pricier than nearby Chitré.

Chitré

\$600–900

HERRERA

60,000 people in Azuero. Famous Carnival, golf for \$100/mo, modern hospital and colonial history since 1558. Great value for services.

David

from \$500

CHIRIQUÍ

Regional capital of the west. Malls, PriceSmart, two private hospitals. Very hot (A/C a must). Gateway to Boquete and Volcán.

Boquete

\$800–1,500+

CHIRIQUÍ

The star destination: spring-like climate, world-class coffee and a very active expat community. Now pricier (condos from \$1,500+). 30 min from David.

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Bocas del Toro

\$500–700

BOCAS DEL TORO

A unique Caribbean archipelago, English everywhere. Surf, snorkel, yoga and an organic market. Off the mainland; bohemian and authentic.

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■ «Undiscovered» towns — bigger savings

Volcán

~\$500

CHIRIQUÍ

Like Boquete 15 years ago, but cheaper. Similar altitude and climate, 24/7 hospital, farmers' market and restaurants 30-50% cheaper.

Santiago

~\$400

VERAGUAS

The country's geographic center. New mega-mall, restaurants and supermarkets. Few expats: a pricing opportunity. Spanish recommended.

Dolega

from \$400

CHIRIQUÍ

Between David and Boquete. Temperate climate, agricultural (coffee, citrus). A 3-bed/2-bath house documented at \$580/mo.

Bugaba

~\$300

CHIRIQUÍ

A «cowboy» feel. Near Costa Rica and David (30 min). A 2-bed ranch for \$177-\$300/mo; local meals \$5 with a drink.

Penonomé

\$400-600

COCLÉ

Capital of Coclé, 2 hrs from the city on the Pan-American. Access to beaches and mountains, vibrant festivals. Very affordable with modern services.



Schooling for expats

Public schools generally lack resources and an international curriculum, so expat families mostly choose private international schools, with quality comparable to the US and Europe.

ASPECT	INFORMATION
Quality (private)	Comparable to US standards; among the best in Central America
Enrollment fee	\$200-\$1,000 per student (family discounts available)
Calendar	Option A: Sep-Jun (US) · Option B: Mar-Dec (Panama)
Mandatory closures	Carnival, Holy Week and Christmas
Student body	Asia, Europe, North & South America: a genuinely multicultural setting
By language / faith	Japanese, French, Chinese, English; Jewish, Catholic, Adventist, Muslim
Most options	Panama City, Coronado and Boquete
Homeschooling	Online platforms and resources available

Top activities & attractions

NATIONAL ICON

The Panama Canal

A marvel of modern engineering. Watching giant ships cross the locks is a one-of-a-kind sight.

CULTURE

Biomuseo

Frank Gehry's iconic architecture. Eight galleries on the origin of the isthmus and its impact on planetary biodiversity.

LIVING NATURE

Emberá Village tour

A canoe trip upriver to an Indigenous Darién community: crafts, a temporary tattoo and lunch on a plantain leaf.

THE SEA

Diving & snorkeling

Marine parks at Coiba Island (Pacific) and Bastimentos (Bocas). World-class marine life.

JUL-OCT SEASON

Whales & dolphins

Whale-watching with a 100% success rate reported over the last two years.

900+ SPECIES

Birdwatching

Panama is one of the best countries in the world for birding.

EXPAT SPORT

Pickleball & paddle

The most popular sport among expats and Panamanians alike: courts in dozens of towns.

ADVENTURE

Surf, hiking & ziplining

Playa Venao and Santa Catalina for surf; canopy tours in Bocas, Boquete and El Valle; jungle and island trails.

NOTE Community

Expats are active in animal-spay clinics, making blankets for newborns, teaching English and other social work.



Transport & getting around

Airports & flights

AIRPORT	DESCRIPTION
Tocumen International (PTY)	Central America's largest. Direct flights worldwide. Panama City
David (DAV)	Domestic flights to the capital. In Chiriquí
Río Hato (RIH)	Coclé. Charter flights from Canada available
Chitré / Azuero	Limited domestic flights
Bocas del Toro (BOC)	Flights from the capital. Gateway to the archipelago

Public transport

MODE	DETAIL
Metro (Panama City)	\$0.35 per ride. Modern; runs end to end across the city
City bus (metrobús)	~\$0.35 per ride with a card
Intercity bus	\$3–\$20 from the Albrook Terminal depending on destination
Taxi	~\$3 in the city. No meter: agree the fare before getting in
Uber / inDrive	Available in the capital; more predictable pricing than taxis
Water taxis (Bocas)	Pangas \$2–\$20 by island; boarded at the dock

Driving in Panama

Driving in Panama City can be a challenge: unnamed streets, signal-free junctions, heavy traffic and horns used as communication. In the interior, driving is far calmer.

RULE / FACT	INFORMATION
Side of the road	Right (same as the US)
Speed limit	100 km/h (62 mph). Traffic enforcement is strict
Requirements	Seat belt and insurance mandatory; obey limits in km/h
Foreign license	Valid for 90 days; then a Panamanian license is required
Fuel	Sold by the liter (~4 liters = 1 gallon)
Horn	A normal means of communication, not a hostile gesture

100 PROPERTY Real estate & rentals

Any foreigner can own property in Panama with the **same rights as a Panamanian**; no visa or residency is required to buy. The professional advice is to rent for at least 12 months before buying, to get to know the area and the market.

Forms of ownership

NOTE Titled Property

Has a deed and an assigned property number. It is **the safest** and the recommended choice for buyers.

CAUTION Rights of Possession (ROP)

Very risky: no formal deed. Many lawyers actively advise against it. Never sign or pay a deposit without prior legal due diligence.

Property tax

PROPERTY VALUE	ANNUAL TAX
Up to \$120,000	Fully exempt — zero property tax
\$120,001 – \$700,000	0.5% on the taxable base in that range
Over \$700,000	0.7% on the amount above \$700,000
Calculation basis	The price of the last registered sale

Rental prices by city

CITY	APPROX. RENT/MO	COMMENT
Panama City (condo)	\$1,200+	2-bed furnished with ocean view. Casco Viejo: higher
Coronado	\$1,000–2,500	Gated community. Playa Blanca cheaper (~\$1,000)
El Valle de Antón	\$1,200+	Upscale, resort area
Pedasí	\$800+	Pricier than Las Tablas/Chitré in recent years
Chitré	\$600–900	Great value for the services
Boquete	\$800+	Gated communities from \$1,500+/mo
David	from \$500	2-bed furnished house at a great price
Bocas del Toro (1-bed)	\$500–700	Caribbean sea view included
Volcán	~\$500	2-bed with all utilities
Santiago	~\$400	Real case: 2-bed with yard for \$275/mo
Dolega	from \$400	3-bed/2-bath house for \$580/mo
Bugaba	~\$300	Real case: nice house for \$177/mo

Key tips before buying

- ✓ Don't buy until you have permanent residency: if the visa is denied, losses can be severe
- ✓ Always hire your own lawyer to review title and deed
- ✓ There is no central MLS: search several agencies and by referral
- ✓ The best deals aren't with agents: they turn up by walking the neighborhoods
- ✓ Avoid «Rights of Possession» (ROP): no solid legal guarantee
- ✓ Areas with many expats = systematically higher prices

11 FINANCE

Currency, banking & finance

Panama is home to one of the largest banking centers in the world, with 130+ international institutions. Using the US dollar as legal tender eliminates exchange-rate risk for those coming from the US.

FINANCIAL ASPECT	DETAIL
Official currency	Balboa (B/.) — pegged 1:1 to the dollar. The USD is legal tender
No central bank	Panama does not «print money»: the money supply is market-driven, with greater macro stability
Monetary backing	The country must generate or export goods and services to earn foreign currency; it does not create money artificially
International banks	130+ institutions, from HSBC to regional banks. The financial hub of Latin America
Opening an account	Relatively easy with a residency visa; without a visa it can be more complex
Recommendation	Choose a bank with online banking in English and Spanish
Taxes (territorial)	Only income earned in Panama is taxed. Pensions, foreign income and online businesses: not taxed
Cryptocurrency	No formal regulation, but virtually no restrictions on personal use

12 EMPLOYMENT Working in Panama

Working as a foreigner comes with important restrictions worth knowing from the outset: breaking them can jeopardize both your residency and your income.

RULE / RESTRICTION	DETAIL
Pensionado Visa	Prohibits working in Panama: you cannot sell products or services on Panamanian soil
Friendly Nations Visa	Includes a work permit: more flexible for formal employment
Foreign-worker quota	Without special authorization, companies may have only 10% foreign payroll
Protected professions	Many (law, medicine, accounting...) are reserved for Panamanians
Minimum wage	~\$2.40/hour; scarce skills can command far higher salaries
Remote / online work	No tax in Panama if the employer or client is foreign
Your own online business	No tax if income comes from abroad: the territorial system rewards the digital entrepreneur

KEY Ideal for digital nomads

Under the territorial system, income from remote work or online businesses with clients abroad **is not taxed in Panama**. It is one of the world's most favorable jurisdictions for digital professionals and entrepreneurs.

13 SENIORS Benefits for retirees & pensioners

Panama has one of the most generous senior-benefit policies in the world. It applies to Pensionado Visa holders and to any retirement-age resident (women 55+, men 60+) with a valid residency visa.

BENEFIT / DISCOUNT	RATE
Entertainment (cinema, concerts, sports)	50%
Transport (bus, boat, train)	30%
Airfare — any destination	25%
Hotels, Monday to Thursday	50%
Hotels, Friday to Sunday	30%
Restaurants	25%
Fast food	15%
Hospital bills (uninsured)	15%
Prescription medication	10%
Medical consultations	20%
Dentistry and eye exams	15%
Utilities (water, electricity, phone)	25%
New car import	Tax-exempt every 2 years
Household goods import	Exempt up to \$10,000 (one-time)
Mortgage interest	Discount on the interest rate

NOTE Backed by law

All of these benefits are mandated by Panamanian law. Establishments are required to apply them.

14 RESIDENCY

Residency visa options

Panama offers one of the most accessible residency systems in the world. The process requires a local attorney in every case, but is relatively straightforward. The visas grant permanent residency with no obligation to live in the country (other than visiting 1 day every 2 years for the Pensionado).

Pensionado (Retiree) Visa — the most popular

REQUIREMENT	DETAIL
Minimum income (1 person)	\$1,000/mo lifetime pension (government, company, military, Social Security)
Minimum income (couple)	\$1,250/mo combined
Low-pension alternative	From \$750/mo if you buy property of \$100,000+ in Panama
Additional dependent	\$250/mo extra per dependent (children –18, or –25 if studying)
Documents	Official pension letter (apostilled), criminal background check (max. 6 months), Panamanian medical certificate
Temporary residency	Card in ~5 business days after filing the application
Permanent residency	4–6 months after the initial application
Renewal	None: it is permanent. Simply visit Panama 1 day every 2 years
Work restriction	May not work or sell services/products in Panama

Friendly Nations Visa — for the working & entrepreneurial

Available to citizens of 50+ countries with professional or economic ties to Panama. It allows you to work and leads to citizenship in 5 years. You must establish **one** qualifying link:

ELIGIBILITY ROUTE	DETAIL
Employment at a Panamanian company	Formal employment contract with a registered company
Your own company	Form or hold shares in a Panamanian company
Real estate investment	\$200,000+ in real estate
Self-economic solvency	Fixed-term deposit of \$200,000+ for 3 years

BENEFIT	DETAIL
Permanent residency	No need to renew
Work permit	Available if the applicant works in Panama
Citizenship	Eligible after 5 years of permanent residency
Timeline	2-3 years to permanent residency

NOTE 50 eligible countries

Andorra · Argentina · Australia · and 47 other nations recognized for their ties to Panama.

Germany	Andorra	Argentina	Australia
Austria	Belgium	Brazil	Canada
Chile	Cyprus	South Korea	Costa Rica
Croatia	Denmark	Slovakia	Spain
United States	Estonia	Finland	France
Greece	Hong Kong	Hungary	Ireland
Israel	Japan	Latvia	Liechtenstein
Lithuania	Luxembourg	Malta	Mexico
Monaco	Montenegro	Norway	New Zealand
Netherlands	Paraguay	Poland	Portugal
United Kingdom	Czech Rep.	San Marino	Serbia
Singapore	South Africa	Sweden	Switzerland
Uruguay			

Qualified Investor Visa — Golden Visa

INVESTMENT OPTION	REQUIREMENT
Real estate	\$300,000 minimum in Panamanian property (pre-construction eligible). Hold 5 years
Securities	\$500,000+ on the Panama Stock Exchange, via a licensed brokerage. 5 years
Fixed bank deposit	\$750,000+ in a fixed-term deposit of at least 5 years, unencumbered

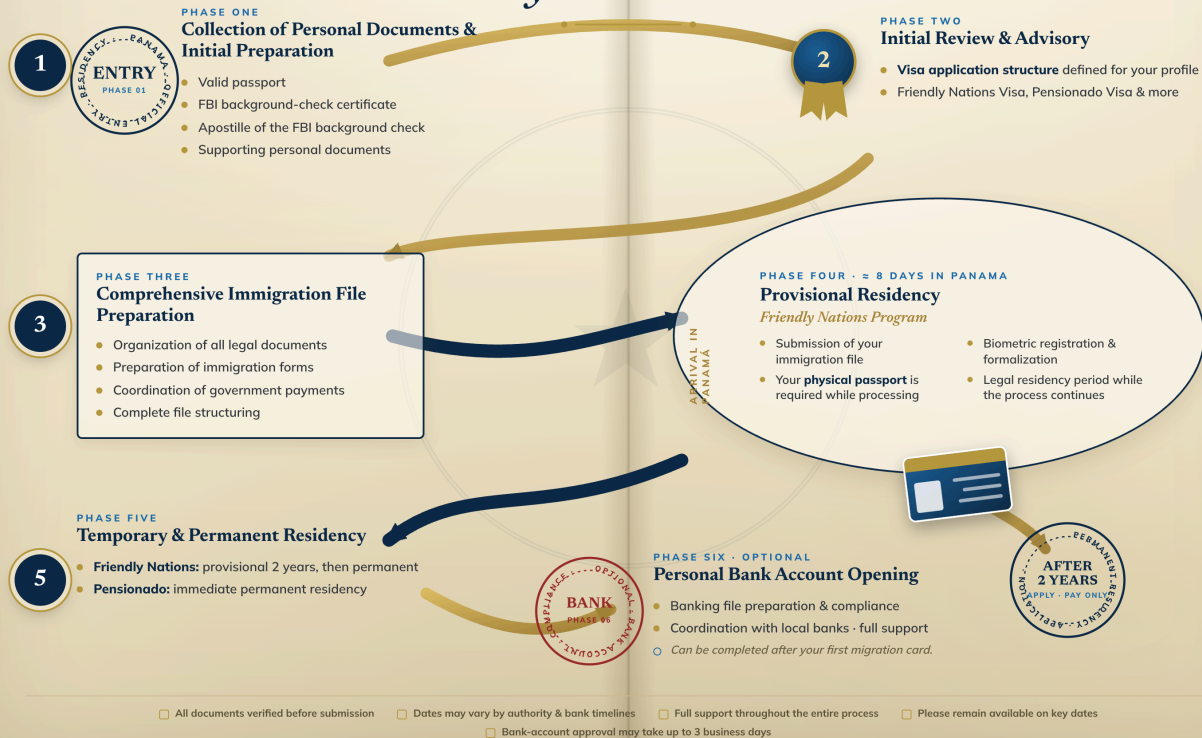
Minimum real estate investment reduced from \$500,000 to \$300,000 as of October 2024. Processed in ~30 business days.

PROCESS	DETAIL
Processing time	~30 business days from filing
Remote start	Can be started from abroad with an attorney; physical presence required for biometrics
Government fees	\$5,000 to the National Treasury + \$5,000 to Immigration (+\$1,000 per dependent at each)
Outcome	Permanent residency for applicant and dependents; allows you to live, work and study
Citizenship	After 5 years of continuous permanent residency

Other visa options

VISA	MAIN REQUIREMENT	NOTES
Reforestation	\$100,000+ and 5 titled hectares in a certified project	«Green» visa. Teak farms popular. Use an experienced attorney
Business Investor	\$160,000 in a legitimate company	Commercial license + social-security registration + 5 Panamanian employees
Self-Economic Solvency	\$300,000 in property and/or a bank CD	For high-net-worth individuals who do not qualify in other categories
Marriage to a Panamanian	Valid legal marriage	2+ years of processing; leads to eventual citizenship

Roadmap & Timeline of Your Residency Process in Panama



Roadmap and timeline of the Panama residency process — Beyond Panama Relocation support at every stage.

KEY Path to citizenship

The vast majority of permanent visas allow you to apply for Panamanian citizenship after **5 years** of continuous residency.

15 IN DEPTH Friendly Nations Visa — detailed guide

The Friendly Nations Visa is the most flexible program for professionals, entrepreneurs, and rentiers from the 50+ eligible countries. Here are the documents, timeline, and additional procedures worth knowing before you start.

Documents per applicant

MAIN APPLICANT

Base requirements

Passport valid 6+ months, second form of ID valid 6+ months, criminal background certificate apostilled or authenticated by a Panamanian consulate (max. 6 months). Couples/families: Panamanian bank account with a minimum of \$5,000.

DEPENDENT SPOUSE

Family tie

Valid passport and second form of ID. Apostilled or authenticated marriage certificate. Apostilled or authenticated criminal background certificate.

DEPENDENT CHILDREN

Minors or students

Valid passport. Birth certificate issued less than 6 months ago, duly apostilled.

Timeline: from provisional to permanent

STEP	DETAIL
1. Residency in process	Temporary residency card while the initial file is being processed
2. Provisional residency	Card valid for 2 years, maintaining the economic or employment tie that originated the application
3. Permanent residency application	Must be filed before the provisional card expires, to avoid monthly fines (maximum 6 months of delay before losing the entire process)
4. Permanent residency card	45 days after receiving permanent residency, the E-Cedula can optionally be requested (valid 2 years) — removes the need to carry passport and card together

Work permit and driver's license

MITRADEL Work permit

Residency alone does not authorize working immediately: it requires a separate process before the Ministry of Labor. **6–7 months** if processed in Panama City; **9–10 months** in David. The indefinite permit requires Panamanian naturalization and 10+ years of residency since the provisional stage.

SERTRACEN Driver's license

Those over 18 with a foreign license can exchange it: authentication at the home consulate, endorsement at Foreign Affairs, a blood type test (if not on the license), and an in-person process with cedula/passport, residency card, original license, and \$40 (vision and hearing tests). Those over 70 require a prior psychological or geriatric evaluation.

Taxes and the path to citizenship

BRACKET / TOPIC	DETAIL
Up to \$11,000	0% income tax
\$11,000 – \$50,000	15%
Over \$50,000	25%
Tax residency certificate	Available with 183+ days of annual presence — useful for double-taxation treaties (Spain, Mexico, France, UK, Germany, among others)
Naturalization	After 5 years of permanent residency; reduced to 3 years if married to a Panamanian or with children born in Panama
Executive approval	The citizenship process adds 2–5 more years for final approval

The state collects revenue mainly through ITBMS (VAT); the territorial system does not tax income earned outside Panama.

Friendly Nations vs. Pensionado

ASPECT	FRIENDLY NATIONS	PENSIONADO
Nationality	Exclusive: only citizens of the 50+ eligible countries	Universal: open to any country in the world
Economic requirement	Local employment, real estate from \$200,000, or a \$200,000 fixed-term deposit	Guaranteed lifetime pension of at least \$1,000/month
Structure	Two steps: 2-year provisional residency, then permanent	Direct permanent residency, no provisional stage
Work permit	Smoother process once temporary residency is obtained	Historically restrictive: geared toward retirees with no intent to compete in the job market
Commercial discounts	Does not include the government discount card	Includes the retiree discount card (25%–50% off medications, restaurants, hotels, transport, entertainment, and flights)

Both programs are solid routes to permanent residency, with no maximum age to apply and the benefit of the territorial tax system.

Frequently asked questions

How long are the documents valid?

Criminal background checks expire after 6 months; the local health certificate after 90 days; bank reference letters after 30 days; the marriage certificate after 6 months.

How long can I stay outside Panama without losing residency?

Provisional residency requires visiting the country at least once every two years. Permanent residency is suspended after two consecutive years or more of absence.

Can I get a tax ID number (RUC)?

Yes. The General Directorate of Revenue (DGI) issues one to permanent residents, foreigners with more than 183 days in the country, or owners of local real estate.

16 WHAT'S NEW

What's new in 2025

Panama's immigration and services framework keeps modernizing. These are the most relevant changes to keep in mind this year.

UPDATE	DETAIL
Qualified Investor Visa	Minimum real estate investment reduced to \$300,000 (from \$500,000), effective October 2024. Processed in 30 business days
Pensionado Visa	Streamlined processes and reduced waiting times at Immigration
Medicare & US insurance	Accepted with direct billing at select hospitals, with no prepayment or reimbursement claims
Public healthcare	Expansion of services across several areas of the interior
Starlink in Panama	Reliable satellite connectivity in previously disconnected rural areas: revolutionizing remote work in the interior
Real estate trends	Chitré, Dolega and Penonomé gain popularity for affordability; Panama City remains the #1 destination
New hospital in Boquete	Public hospital under construction, opening expected 2025
International education	Bilingual schools and distance learning gaining ground among expat families

17 EXPERIENCES

Expatriate testimonials

The following testimonials reflect real experiences of people who chose to move to Panama, many of them supported by specialized advisors like Beyond Panama Relocation at every stage of the relocation process.

On the relocation process

“It was eye-opening and transformative. The team gave us absolutely everything we needed to feel confident about our move to Boquete. We would have made very costly mistakes without that professional support.”

Sarah and Tom D.

Expats in Boquete · 2026

“We bought the guide a year ago and have already saved more than it cost us. We used the recommended immigration attorney, bought a car and handled the licenses. Absolutely worth every penny.”

Marie

Permanent resident · March 2026

“We arrived as strangers and left as family. If you're planning to move to Panama, do it well-supported — you won't be disappointed.”

Gena

Relocation to Panama · January 2026

“Having legal, medical, insurance and visa advice all in one place is invaluable. It would have taken me a year to gather all that information on my own, if I'd managed at all.”

Luiz

October 2025

Real life as an expat

“The level of medical care surprised me. My sister, a nurse in California, traveled here alarmed; once she saw the equipment and the care, she said it was more modern than the hospital where she works. That's priceless.”

Resident expat

Emergency experience · Boquete

“The territorial system radically changes the financial equation. My US pension isn't taxed here, and on top of that I get 25% off restaurants and 20% off medical visits. The real purchasing power is impressive.”

North American retiree

Pensionado Visa holder · Chitré, since 2024

Why work with Beyond Panama Relocation?

We support individuals, families and investors through the entire relocation process to Panama: from assessing the most suitable visa type to housing, banking and adapting to local life. The difference between moving «blind» and doing it with specialized advice can amount to tens of thousands of dollars in avoided mistakes.

- ✓ Personalized assessment of your profile and recommended visa
- ✓ Support with renting and buying property
- ✓ Coordination with trusted immigration attorneys
- ✓ Verified network of attorneys, doctors and agents
- ✓ Guidance on banking, insurance and essential services
- ✓ Ongoing advice after you arrive

Executive summary & next steps

Panama brings together, in one place, the combination expats value most: low cost of living, modern infrastructure, an excellent climate, affordable quality healthcare, a favorable tax system, active expat communities and some of the most welcoming residency programs in the world.

It is not a paradise for everyone, but it is for those who arrive informed, with realistic expectations and the right support. The difference between a successful relocation and a costly disappointment lies in the preparation beforehand and the quality of your advisors.

Next-steps checklist

#	RECOMMENDED ACTION
1	Determine your profile: retiree / working / investor / digital nomad
2	Identify the most suitable visa type (Pensionado, Friendly Nations, Investor...)
3	Contact Beyond Panama Relocation for an initial, no-obligation assessment
4	Visit Panama in person: at least 1-2 weeks in the areas of interest
5	Rent for at least 12 months before any purchase decision
6	Begin the visa process with a verified immigration attorney
7	Open a bank account once you have temporary residency
8	Get a local SIM, sign up for internet and install WhatsApp
9	Evaluate health-insurance options (local, international or self-insure)
10	Integrate into the local expat community and support networks

Your partner for relocating to Panama

Take the first step with a personalized, no-obligation assessment. We help you choose the right path and execute it with legal certainty from start to finish.

- ✓ No-obligation visa assessment
- ✓ End-to-end support throughout
- ✓ Network of verified professionals
- ✓ Real, on-the-ground experience